BLACK WALNUT CREAM TART
WITH SUNFLOWER CRUST AND SEASONAL BERRIES

makes one 9-inch tart

It's remarkable how rich black walnuts become when pureed; their fat makes the puree very creamy, and their funky, sweet scent is floral and unique. This might sound odd, but I really feel like you can taste that black walnuts came from a tree. They make an incredible stand-in for dairy in this tart, nicely set in a crisp sunflower seed crust. To highlight their sweetness and depth of flavor, I toast the walnuts, but if you want a more neutral-tasting cream, you can skip that step.

Agar-agar is a natural, vegetarian gelatin-like agent for setting the cream. I use ½ teaspoon of the powdered form, which makes the filling sliceable but still softly creamy. If you prefer a firmer set, increase the agar to ¾ teaspoon.

Make the crust: Preheat the oven to 350°F. Using a little sunflower oil, lightly grease the sides of a tart pan with a removable bottom (one that holds at least 6 cups of volume) or a 9-inch springform pan.

In a food processor, combine the sunflower seeds, flour, and salt and pulse until the seeds are finely chopped. With the machine running, add the oil, ¼ cup water, the agave syrup, and maple syrup and let it run until it holds together like a dough.

Press the dough into the bottom and at least 1 inch up the sides of the pan. If the dough gets sticky, dampen your hands with a little water as you press.

Bake the tart shell for 20 to 30 minutes, until dry to the touch, deeply golden at the edges, and lightly browned everywhere else. Let cool. Leave the oven on.

Make the filling: Spread the walnuts on a baking sheet and toast in the oven for about 4 minutes, until fragrant.

Transfer the walnuts to a small saucepan. Add 2 cups water and the agar-agar and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Turn off the heat and let cool so it's warm but no longer steaming. Transfer the walnuts and their cooking liquid to a high-powered blender. Add the maple syrup and salt and puree until smooth.

Pour the filling into the cooled shell and refrigerate uncovered for at least 2 hours, until chilled and set. Garnish the top of the tart with fresh berries and serve.

Note

- *You can purchase amaranth flour, but if you can't find it, you can grind 3 tablespoons amaranth seeds in a spice grinder to yield about ¼ cup. Sift the flour through a fine-mesh sieve, if needed, to remove any larger pieces. (If you need to clear any lingering flavors in your grinder before you make the flour, grind 1 tablespoon amaranth first and discard.)*

CRUST

¼ cup sunflower oil, plus more for the pan

8 ounces sunflower seeds (about 2 cups)

¼ cup amaranth flour (see Note)

¼ teaspoon fine sea salt

2 teaspoons agave syrup

1½ teaspoons maple syrup

FILLING

8 ounces black walnut meat (about 1½ cups small pieces)

½ teaspoon agar-agar (or ¾ teaspoon for a firmer set)

⅔ cup maple syrup

¼ teaspoon fine sea salt

Fresh seasonal berries, such as mulberries, wild blackberries, or other berries, for garnish